

Alabama Learning Hour

Powwow, -o/-bi forms, asking questions

September 24th, 2026

1 Naat̓iilka Dialogue

Naasok sahmiḥchō powwow-kafa?

What happened at the powwow?

① Maxine, an elder, asks Tanya about the Powwow.

Maxine: Naksok ittanowwahchō bitkafa?

Tanya: Avak aayati piyaaka.

Maxine: Avak naason sahmiḥchō?

Tanya: Bitlihan hiichati.

Bokoko batliyon īhaaloti

Hono okchakkohchon choopati

① English.

Maxine: Who was at the powwow?

Tanya: Ava was there yesterday.

Maxine: What did Ava do?

Tanya: She saw the dancers.

She listened to the drums beating

She bought a blue shirt.

Naasok sahmihchō powwow-kafa?

What happened at the powwow?

② Alabama.

Tanya: Himaakanihtaya Avaya bitkafon aayalo.
Avak illihlahchi.
Oolimpa wihlihchi.

Maxine: Oolimpa saahchon inchampolihchi?

Tanya: Avaya paspa spoyatlin inchampolihchi.
Avak Powwow-kan stinkaanomolo.

② English.

Tanya: Today Ava is at the Powwow.
Now she is hungry.
She is looking for food.

Maxine: Which food does she like?

Tanya: Ava likes frybread.
Ava really likes the Powwow.

2 Vocabulary

Nouns

Powwow-Related

aabitka	dancing ground
bokoko	drum
bitka	dance
bitliha	dancers
chassi bitka	corn dance
chokfi bitka	rabbit dance
isbitka holikfa	regalia/clothes for dancing
hono	skirt
Powwow-ka	Powwow

Food & Drink

nipo	meat
oolimpa	food
paspa spoyatli	frybread
tiika (champoli)	(sweet) tea
yakchi	yakchi

Date & Time

himaaka nihta	today
piyaaka	yesterday

Verbs

Ka-Verbs

afaaka	to laugh
isko	to drink

Li-Verbs

bokoko batli
bitli
chiyahli
ilakomayli
sahmi
wihli
inchampoli

to beat/hit drums
to dance
to walk
to swim
to happen how? be like what?
to look for
to like the taste of

Simple-Verbs

aaya
choopa
hiicha
hompani
ittanowwa
inhaalo
okchakko
oompa
illihla
stinkaano

to be located/around (for one or two people)
to buy
to see/watch
to play
to be located/around (for multiple people)
to listen to someone/somebody
to be blue
to eat
to be hungry
to like

3 Grammar

3.1 Case on Nouns

- In the example about you might notice that when we build a sentence there are these little pieces on the end of some words.

(1) Tanyak and Avan

- These pieces that appear on nouns are called *case*.
- Case tells us the role of the noun in the sentence: who is doing what to whom.
- The **k** tells us it is the **subject** of the sentence. For now, we can think of the subject as the noun which the sentence is “about”.
- For example, the noun in agent verbs marked with this **k**.

– *Avak bitliti* “Ava danced”, *anok chiyahliliti* “I walked”

- Case morphemes which indicate the subject, like **k**, are known as **nominative case**.

★ What about situations where there is more than one noun?

– When there is a subject and an object that is called a **transitive sentence**.

– *I saw him, I helped you*

- If there is an **agent** who is *doing something* to another noun, then the agent is marked with **nominative case, k**.
- The noun that is being **affected** by the subject is marked with **oblique case, n**.

Simple Two-Noun Present tense Sentence Recipe

[**Doer** + **-k** + **Affected** + **-n** + **Verb** + **-hchi**]

Example:

- (2) **Ava-k** **Jacobka-n** **hiicha-hchi**
Ava-doer Jacob-affected see-right.now.
'Ava sees Jacob.'

Let's practice!

Fill in the blanks to make a sentence with the words below!

- (Ex:) _____-k _____-n hiicha**hchi**
Ava-k **Jacobka-n** hiicha**hchi**
'Ava sees Jacob'

- | | | | |
|-----|-----------------------------|-----|--------------------|
| (3) | a. ifa — dog | (6) | a. tayyi — woman |
| | b. kati — cat | | b. chassi — corn |
| (4) | a. Jacob (<i>Jacobka</i>) | (7) | a. Tanya |
| | b. Tanya | | b. mobilka — car |
| (5) | a. łało — fish | (8) | a. nita — bear |
| | b. foosi — bird | | b. choffi — rabbit |

3.2 Stative *-o/-bi*

- In today's dialogue, Maxine and Tanya talked about events happening right now.
- Now we will discuss one way to talk about "right now," using the stative *-o/-bi*.
- In previous sessions, we have talked about "patient verbs." Recall the pieces *cha-* 'my' and *chi-* 'your,' along with our recipe for patient verbs, but this time using *-o/-bi*:

Patient Verb Sentence Easy Recipe (Stative O/BI, Statement)

If the verb ends on the vowel *-o* (e.g. *kaano*), this tense is *-bi*.

- (9) [Patient + k] [Patient + Verb + Tense]
 [ano + k] [cha- + kaano + bi]
 I my good is
 Meaning: 'I am good.'

If the verb does not end on *-o*, this tense will be *-o*. The vowel before it will disappear: *hoopa* → *hoop-o*, *hoyap.li* → *hoyap.l-o*.

- (10) [Patient + k] [Patient + Verb + Tense]
 [ano + k] [cha- + hoyapl + o]
 I my tired is
 Meaning: 'I am tired.'

- The *-o/bi tense*, which we might call a stative tense, describes different kinds of states that individuals can be in.
- With verbs like *kaano* 'be good', *hoopa* 'be sick', *hoyapli* 'be tired', it describes currently ongoing states.
- With verbs that describe non-stative events, e.g. *dancing*, or *opening*, the sentences are usually interpreted as 'we're now in a state that results from this event happening', 'in a state of having done this event.'

- (11) Ava-**k** okkich-**on** 'Ava has opened the door.'
 Ava door
 tiyap.l-**o**.
 open.LI-STATE
- (12) Ava-**k** bit.l-**o**.
 Ava dance.LI-STATE
 'Ava has danced.'

- O/bi forms are statements. To form a corresponding question, we simply drop this tense and add nasalization:

Patient Verb Sentence Easy Recipe (Stative O/BI, Question)

- (13) [Patient + k] [Patient + Verb.Tense]
 [isno + k] [chi- + hoyapli]?
 you your tired
 Meaning: ‘Are you tired?’

Let’s practice! *Ask your classmate how they are feeling.*
Answer using some of the verbs below.

Examples of Alabama Patient Verbs expressing Feelings

Verb	Translation	Verb	Translation
ayokpa	be happy	noklikiicha	be afraid
kaano	be good	małatli	be scared, wild
yawoota	be jittery, nervous	hoopa	be sick
yowaapa	be uneasy, tense	hoyapli	be tired

3.3 Asking Questions

- Now that you know how to ask basic questions, you can practice asking people more complicated questions; for example, “What are you doing?” “Who did you see?”
- Questions that use words like *what*, *when*, *where*, *why* are called *wh*-questions in English. Alabama has these too, but they don’t usually start with *wh*!
- Today we will learn two of these words: ‘what?’—**naasok/naason**; and ‘who?’— **naksok/nakson**.

Asking ‘Wh-Questions’ with Two Nouns Easy Recipe

(14) **Question**

[**Subject** + **k**] [**Object** + **n**] [**Verb** + **-hchõ**]?

Ava-k **naaso**-n wihli-hchõ?

‘What did Ava look for?’

(15) **Statement**

[**Subject** + **k**] [**Object** + **n**] [**Verb** + **-ti**].

Ava-k oolimpa-n wihli-ti.

‘Ava looked for food’.

Question Words:

naaso-	what
nakso-	who

- Add *-k* to the ‘Subject’ of the action.
- Add *-n* to the ‘Object’ of the action. Who is it happening to? Who is undergoing the action?
- When including a question word, put *naaso-* and *nakso-* in the ‘Subject’ or ‘Object’ positions. Make sure to add *-k* or *-n*.
- Add *hchõ* for questions or *-ti* for statements because we’re talking about the past.
- First put the Subject, then the Object, then the Verb—and you’re done!

Let’s Practice! *How would you ask this in Alabama?*

(16) *nakso-* - who?

- a. Q: Who ate (*oompa*) the frybread (*paspa spoyatli*)?
A: Ava ate the frybread.
- b. Q: Who bought (*choopa*) the skirt (*hono*)?
A: Ava bought the skirt.

- c. Q: Who saw (*hiicha*) the dancers (*bitliha*)?
A: Ava saw the dancers.
- d. Q: Whom did Ava see (*hiicha*)?
A: Ava saw the dancers (*bitliha*).
- e. Q: Whom did Maxine listen to (*īhaalo*)?
A: Maxine listened to Tanya.

(17) naaso- - what?

- a. Q: What did Ava eat (*oompa*)?
A: Ava ate the frybread (*paspa spoyatli*).
- b. Q: What did Ava buy (*choopa*)?
A: Ava bought the skirt (*hono*).
- c. Q: What did Ava listen to (*īhaalo*)?
A: She listened to the drum (*bokoko*).
- d. Q: What did Ava write (*hosso*)?
A: Ava wrote a letter/paper (*holisso*).
- e. Q: What ate (*oompa*) the chicken (*akaaka*)?
A: The wolf (*waso*) ate the chicken.